



HONG KONG CHINA

Dim Sum by the South China Sea

“A dream of Manhattan, arising from the South China Sea” – modern travel writer Pico Iyer’s description perfectly captures the East–West paradox that is Hong Kong. From imperial stronghold to opium port, Cold War enclave to today’s global financial hub, this teeming city still delights in its traditional Cantonese cuisine, especially its bite-sized, delicious dim sum.



Prior to 1997 Hong Kong had been a British colony for 155 years, but this vibrant business center remains emphatically Chinese under its Western veneer. While you can shop for Armani suits or be serenaded by a string quartet over afternoon tea at an elegant colonial hotel, the dominant language is Cantonese and the city’s ultra-modern harborside has been laid out according to the traditional aesthetic principles of feng shui.

As stores open and the engines of commerce fire up for the day, in the oasis of Kowloon Park, birds chirp and swoop between fig trees, and senior citizens greet each other after their morning tai chi exercises with “Jousahn, yum cha, yum cha!” – “Good morning, let’s go for dim sum!” When it comes to eating, Hong Kong is the best place in the world to try Cantonese cooking, with its fresh flavors and contrasting textures, and there’s no better way to sample its variety than with dim sum, or “little choices” – dainty portions of fried or steamed snacks. In Hong Kong, dim sum is better

known as *yum cha* – “with tea” – and a pot is an essential part of the meal. Favorite is *bo lei*, a dark, strong brew said to help the digestion.

The Hong Kong dim sum experience involves wading into a busy restaurant, finding a free table, then ordering from the carts laden with dishes and steamer baskets that constantly cruise by. *Har gau* dumplings, their shrimp fillings glowing pink through translucent wrappings; little steamed beef balls, smooth, springy-textured, and flavored with minced celery; fluffy steamed buns filled with scented *char siu* roast pork; aromatic sticky rice steamed in lotus leaves; *cheung fun*, meat wrapped in sheets of paper-thin rice noodles – the main problem is deciding what not to try, so it’s no surprise that a dim sum brunch often stretches into the afternoon. It’s the perfect way to fortify yourself for sightseeing and, above all in this city built on trade, for shopping, whether browsing in glitzy high-end Central, haggling in hectic Causeway Bay and Nathan Road, or diving into the heady Temple Street night bazaar.

Three Days in Hong Kong

Hong Kong has matchless shopping opportunities, but look beyond them and you’ll discover an engaging mix of modern architecture, traditional temples, street markets, island life, and even fine beaches.

DAY ONE Explore Hong Kong Island by riding the Peak Tram to the **Peak** for views over the city, then catch a bus to explore traditional Chinese medicine shops and the smoky **Man Mo Temple** at Sheung Wan. After lunch, sunbathe or stroll on the south coast’s **Shek O** beach, then mix with expats over a drink at one of **Lan Kwai Fong**’s many bars.

DAY TWO Catch the romantic Star Ferry across the harbor to **Kowloon** and Nathan Road’s jewelers and clothing shops, then work north through the lively jade, goldfish, and ladies’ markets. Ride the MTR to Diamond Hill’s antique-style **Nan Lian Gardens**, before returning to the harbor for the classic nighttime view of Hong Kong Island’s skyline.

DAY THREE Head to **Lantau Island** and ride the Ngong Ping 360° cable car to the serene, 110-foot- (34-m-) high **Big Buddha**, then visit the stilt fishing village of **Tai O** for a chance to see pink dolphins, before returning to Hong Kong Island by ferry.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

A major hub, **Hong Kong International Airport** connects directly to much of the globe. The **Airport Express** train has direct links to the downtown and Kowloon. **Buses**, the **MTR subway**, and **taxis** are comprehensive and efficient.

WHERE TO STAY

The **Eaton Hotel** (inexpensive) is friendly and functional. www.eaton-hotel.com
Hotel LKF (moderate) is classy and in boutique style. www.hotel-lkf.com.hk
The Peninsula Hotel (expensive) offers colonial-era luxury. www.peninsula.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Find the helpful Hong Kong Tourism Board at Causeway Bay MTR station and Tsim Sha Tsui Star Ferry Pier (Kowloon); www.discoverhongkong.com

